

Good Enough?



Robert Sovereign-Smith, Editor

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Although a lot of us use the phrase, “It’s not quantity, but quality that matters”, how many of us practice what we preach? Think about it, which of your senses is most active right now? Thanks to the cramming of our cities, sound and smell are certainly not our favourite senses anymore. Everything is visual these days, from the ads that you’re bombarded with, to the HDTVs you shell out the big bucks for — to watch those same advertisements, incidentally. The victory of consumerism seems to have happened a long time ago.

What this does, however, is put on a very distant backburner the technological marvels that could be accomplished for one of my favourite senses — sound. With all the supposedly space-age technology at hand, why can’t we have a recording studio-like experience in our living rooms? What happened to DVD audio? What happened to those guys who promised to turn my walls into magnificent sounding speakers? Did they fail because my walls are now also someone else’s, and my neighbours don’t share my taste in music?

These are questions I’ve asked myself, and the answers are usually simple. All of the above already exist, as finished products, or at worst, as prototypes in labs around the world, but they’re way too expensive, or basically just not popular enough to find their way to the mainstream.

We’re slowly but surely becoming a society that is willing to “settle” for less. Previously in this space I’ve talked about the idiot box, and how the programming we’re subjected to is just trash; the same seems to be invading every other aspect of our lives. Parents, who push their kids to get near 100 per cent scores in school, then go out and buy sub-standard stuff for their homes, because it was cheap, or because it “looked good”.

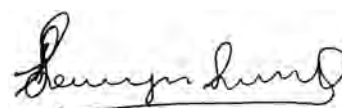
The YouTube generation — of which I am also a part — is impatient, and wants everything quick, and easy. We moved from analogue sound to digital, because it was easier to store — I have a quiet laugh every time I think of that, because the same forces that drove that change are the ones suffering today, because MP3 came along and absolutely trounced their earnings with piracy.

The same applies for video. Most people ooh and aah at the beauty of 1080p HD, not realising that even old movies captured on professional, analogue film cameras can actually be scanned and displayed at several times HD resolution. It’s not done because the sub-standard analogue-to-digital conversion technology hasn’t caught up yet. Decades ago, we could have had high-definition TVs (not LCDs, but HD still), but not many bothered to try, because it wasn’t economical to send signals of that resolution over the air to your home — and still isn’t. Why hurry to change that? You’re already buying expensive 1080p TVs, are happy watching lower resolution videos on them, or you’re willing to buy expensive (Rs. 1,800) Blu-ray Discs, just to get a video experience that you really should have got a decade ago. That translates to win-win for certain people, and spend-spend for you.

Yes, everyone should have access to technologies — even the sub-standard ones of today — because it’s what’s revolutionising the world. However, that shouldn’t stop us from demanding more from our products. It’s the only way to ensure that technology regularly surges ahead.

At Digit, we’re aware of the rather large responsibility we carry on our shoulders, which is to ensure that each one of you is always aware of what’s good, and what’s not. Through our monthly tests and reviews, we try and ensure that you choose the right products, and every December, we do the mother of all tests to bring out the Zero1 Awards. All this is done in the hope that you will see the merits of buying good products. If you only buy what’s good, brands are forced to innovate and improve to cater to your gourmet tastes. This makes better technology cheaper, and advancements faster.

Yes, you may have to spend a little more (not always) to help this along, but would you rather spend your hard earned money on products that are worth it, or would you rather continue buying things that are barely “good enough”? 


editor@thinkdigit.com